

AI's shocking growth from 0.0064% of energy use in 2024 to 0.017% in 2025

Posted by u/Human_certified • 0 points • 27 comments

[I just like the robot](https://preview.redd.it/doroy8dv606f1.png?width=3352&format=png&auto=webp&s=7d867e13fc144c670694ace1dc453f9691adb38b)

https://journal.uptimeinstitute.com/generative-ai-and-global-power-consumption-high-but-not-that-high/

In other words: going from **nothing** to less than a blip.

***"But that's as much as 750,000 average US households!"**

Yes, and that is **very little**.

There are 8,000,000,000 people in world, and every year 70,000,000 more, all consuming power.

"But the** ***training!"

Yes, that's included, about 20% of the amount.

***"But it's increasing!"**

Yes, and global power consumption was **always** going to increase **exponentially,** with or without AI, even under the most utopian predictions. It goes hand in hand with lowering poverty.

***"But it wasn't there before!"**

Yes, it's a permanent addition to the global economy. What's it supposed to do? **Not** consume power, unlike literally every other industry? Or should we never have new things again?

***"But \[local issue\]"**

Yes, absolutely \[local issue\]! Petition and protest, by all means. I'm sure you have a point.

If your own sources are insanely higher, then maybe your sources are just insane.

Just ask yourself:

\- Why do no serious policymakers seem to share these concerns?

\- Why would so much of the world's electricity apparently be given away for nearly free?

\- Why is everyone in the industry simply planning instead of panicking?

\- How can a few tens of billions in venture capital somehow cover all this power?

\- How can a phone generate dozens of images, if an image requires more power than to charge a phone?

\- Your sources don't happen to already dislike AI, do they?

\- Etc.

Please just do the math.

No weird analogies, no comparisons to Bhutan, the Empire State Building, or ancient lies about "ten Google searches" to hide that the numbers are so tiny *that they won't even show up in a pie chart.*

Also, no references to hysterically uninformed articles from 2022, or to that one Dutch guy who writes a clueless paper every year that dutifully gets ripped to shreds, or links to single-author "power could quintuple in six years if demand is squared and unicorns sprout wings" preprints on the arXiv.

If you simply do the math honestly, you'll find the whole thing is a losing argument, irrelevant at the global scale unless you're in a data center procurement dept.

AI power use ***is just not that much, period.***

And since energy isn't free, whatever we're using it for must be worth it to someone, somewhere.

Comments

u/Humble-Agency-3371 • 1 points • 2025-06-10 23:15 UTC

Google's AI datacenter burns 6 billion gallons of water a year, (Not even counting Open ai) but yea AI's power and resource impact is *nonexistent*

u/PerfectStudent5 • 2 points • 2025-06-10 16:35 UTC

Honestly, even as an anti, I'll never be able to take any argument relating to environment seriously, because energy and water is only an infrastructure problem of which we've already become quite advanced and efficiently green at, and being angry at AI for it really just delays the fact that the entire world is shifting toward an energy heavy society *regardless* of AI.

u/DaveG28 • 2 points • 2025-06-10 14:46 UTC

I mean - I wish there could be more sensible discussion on this instead of the complete denial loop from the brocult.

When Altman says saying please and thank you costs billions, most of that cost is energy (all the rest and infrastructure etc are there without saying please/thank you).

When Google says both - 1. All it's carbon footprint increases in the last few years are because of ai, AND 2. It will no longer meet it's previous medium term carbon commitments because of ai - it's really, really, not unreasonable to suggest this is not good for the environment and that maybe some focus should be put on making that energy usage more climate friendly (if you need fresh potable water in and output unpotable water - build the sites where there isn't a scarcity of fresh water, power the sites from renewables etc).

It's not just on ai, but any growth energy consuming industry.

u/clopticrp • 2 points • 2025-06-10 12:32 UTC

I only have one related question.

Who has serious policy makers?

u/Mataric • 9 points • 2025-06-10 07:41 UTC

Social media is responsible for 0.61% of global emissions (2023 data). Compare that to the 0.017% of global energy usage for AI, and it's 35 times worse.

The irony of complaining about AI's energy usage on social media is always funny to me.

u/Tyler_Zoro • 20 points • 2025-06-10 04:43 UTC

These estimates generally just take all global computer infrastructure and treat it as "AI". Or they take estimates of how many units of something like high-end GPUs have been sold and extrapolate numbers from there.

Neither of these is an accurate assessment, but they're generally not interested in accuracy, just outrage.

u/Human_certified • 3 points • 2025-06-10 12:07 UTC

Yep.

If I cherry-pick the sources, I could easily get it down to a tenth of this. Everyone uses their own flawed definitions. But sticking to trustworthy sources (energy agencies, researchers with a long track record and no axe to grind), it's very hard to get the number any higher. This really is a "worst case" calculation.

u/Tyler_Zoro • 1 points • 2025-06-10 14:44 UTC

> sticking to trustworthy sources

There are no trustworthy sources. That's the problem, and why it's so easy for these studies to be completely fictitious.

1. We don't know what ratio of AI to all other forms of compute any given company has going in their datacenters. We definitely know that datacenter capacity has been rising sharply for decades without AI being a major component, and we know there's been a sharp rise in AI infrastructure, but we don't really know which of those is the dominant factor or to what exact extent.
2. We don't know how much infrastructure has been built in anticipation and how much is actually being utilized.
3. We don't know how much of the GPU usage is training vs. running models. That's a big deal if you're going to try to assess how much each request costs.
4. We don't know the volume of requests.
5. We don't know how much work is done per request. Chain-of-thought, for example, requires multiple passes through the model to analyze the step-by-step reasoning, but how many and across how many distinct models is a proprietary secret.

It's just impossible to accurately measure right now, and anyone who tells you they have a measure is blowing smoke up your ass. Ask yourself, in each case, why is this particular source lying and telling me that they can produce that number? What's in it for them?

u/MessyKerbal • -8 points • 2025-06-10 04:00 UTC

Have you ever considered like... generative AI just isn't good at what it does?

u/Lance789 • 1 points • 2025-06-11 09:10 UTC

so why people cry about ai replacing them then? atleast put some thought into what you say

u/MydnightWN • 2 points • 2025-06-10 12:33 UTC

Have you ever considered like... you just aren't good at what you do?

u/MessyKerbal • 0 points • 2025-06-10 14:09 UTC

You're right, I'm not good at what I do. But I am better than AI.

u/MydnightWN • 2 points • 2025-06-10 14:12 UTC

Looks at profile

Doubt.

u/WideAbbreviations6 • 2 points • 2025-06-10 09:59 UTC

Today I learned that winning art competitions, making the charts, and predicting the weather with more accuracy than had ever been possible means the tools you use just aren't good at what they do.

u/Sthenosis • 6 points • 2025-06-10 06:25 UTC

If it's not... why are people getting replaced?

u/ack1308 • 5 points • 2025-06-10 06:22 UTC

Have you considered that it's getting better at it?

u/GBJI • 9 points • 2025-06-10 04:53 UTC

Have you considered that many users of AI tools already had a successful career and were already good at what they were doing ?

u/Comic-Engine • 4 points • 2025-06-10 03:37 UTC

Great post

u/SuchNefariousness365 • 6 points • 2025-06-10 03:16 UTC

It took me quite a bit to realize 0.0064 is less than 0.17

u/ifandbut • 3 points • 2025-06-10 10:49 UTC

People need to pick up a book more than a pencil.

u/No_Newspaper2040 • 1 points • 2025-06-10 06:37 UTC

Me too.

u/DaylightDarkle • 2 points • 2025-06-10 02:47 UTC

>I just like the robot

<https://i.imgur.com/1N0UjV3.jpeg>

u/schattig_eeenhoortje • 15 points • 2025-06-10 02:33 UTC

AI also promotes jobs that can be done remotely (AI development/research, data curation). More remote jobs -> less carbon footprint from cars. Cars and planes are orders of magnitude worse for the environment than AI